

SMALLSPACEHOME.CA

The Move-In Week Survival Kit

A day-by-day plan for your first week in a new Canadian apartment — unpacking, setup, and the paperwork you can't skip.

\$9 CAD

Small Space Home

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SmallSpaceHome.ca is a Canadian digital publisher specializing in small-space living guides. Our mission is to help renters and homeowners across Canada transform their homes — no matter how small — into spaces they love.

How to Use This Kit

Read it roughly in order the first time, since later chapters build on earlier decisions. Keep it open on your phone during the actual move. The checklists at the end are designed to be used, not just read.

Important: Provincial deposit and tenancy rules vary. Confirm your rights with your province's tenancy board.

Introduction

Moving is one of the most stressful life events. Psychologists rank it alongside divorce and job loss on the stress scale. Not because moving is inherently difficult — but because it combines physical exhaustion, financial pressure, and emotional upheaval all at once.

You're leaving a place that knew you. A kitchen where you knew which drawer had the utensils. A bathroom where you knew how the shower temperature worked. A neighbourhood where you knew the closest coffee shop. All of that is gone, and none of the new information has arrived yet.

This guide exists because the first week in a new apartment sets the tone for your entire tenancy. The decisions you make in the first seven days — unpacking order, address registration, utility setup, landlord relationship — determine whether you spend the next 12 months feeling settled or scrambling.

Over the next pages, you'll learn exactly what to do each day of your first week. Not everything — just the essentials. By day seven, you'll have a functioning home, a clear head, and the confidence that you've got this.

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01

CHAPTER 1 OF 12

The First Hour

“It smells like paint and cleaning products.”

Chapter Hook

The moving truck is on its way. You're standing in your empty apartment. The keys are in your hand. The walls are bare. The floors are clean. It smells like paint and cleaning products. This is the moment everything changes.

Why This Matters

The first hour in your new apartment is the most important hour of the entire move. What you do in that hour determines whether the rest of the week is smooth or chaotic. Most people waste this hour by carrying boxes in random order. The smartest movers use it to set up the systems that make everything else easier.

The Build

Before the truck arrives:

1. **Walk through with your phone camera.** Photograph every pre-existing scuff, dent, crack, and stain. Open every cabinet. Flush every toilet. Turn on every tap. Check for leaks under every sink. Email the photos to yourself with the date. If you don't do this, your landlord may claim your damage deposit for marks that existed before you moved in.
2. **Mark your parking spot.** Many new renters get towed on move-in day because they assumed their parking was where they parked during the viewing. Confirm the spot number or location with your landlord or building manager.

3. **Test the utilities.** Turn on lights in every room. Check that outlets work. Flush toilets. Run the shower. If something doesn't work, call the landlord before you move a single box in.

What to buy before the truck arrives:

- A plunger (\$8-10)
- Toilet paper and paper towels
- One towel and one set of sheets for the first night
- Basic cleaning supplies (all-purpose cleaner, sponge, dish soap, garbage bags)
- A box cutter or scissors

Documents to collect:

- Your lease — scanned and stored on your phone and in cloud storage
- The move-in inspection report — filled out, photographed, and submitted within your province's deadline
- Your landlord's emergency contact number
- Your tenant insurance policy number and claim line

Design Insight

The first hour is what designers call a **"critical moment"** — a point where a small investment of effort creates an outsized return.

Photographing the apartment takes 15 minutes. It can save you hundreds or thousands of dollars in deposit disputes. The return on that 15 minutes is higher than almost anything else you'll do during the entire move.

Real Example

Mike, Toronto one-bedroom, 500 sq ft

Mike moved into a Toronto apartment that looked clean during the viewing. After moving in, he noticed a crack in the bathroom tile and a stain on the living room carpet. He hadn't photographed either.

Before: Mike had no evidence of pre-existing damage.

Actions taken: He emailed his landlord immediately with photos he took after moving in, hoping to prove the damage predated him. But those photos were timestamped after move-in day — they showed the damage existed, not when it happened. Without a move-in-day record, Mike had no way to prove the crack and stain weren't his.

After: The landlord deducted \$200 from Mike's deposit for the damage, and Mike had no evidence to contest it.

Lessons learned: Mike now photographs every apartment before moving a single box in. He saves the photos in a folder called "Move-In Evidence" with the date.

Quick Wins

- **Take 10 photos** of your empty apartment right now. Email them to yourself.
- **Flush every toilet** and run every tap. Takes 5 minutes.
- **Buy a plunger** before you need one.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Not photographing the apartment. This is the single most common deposit loss. Photograph everything before you move in.

Mistake #2: Assuming the parking spot is obvious. Confirm the spot number with the landlord. Getting towed on move-in day adds \$200+ to your moving costs.

Designer Tips

The photo checklist: Photograph: every wall (especially corners), every floor (especially under windows), every countertop, every cabinet interior, every appliance, every window and window screen, every door (both sides), every light fixture, every outlet and switch plate.

The email trick: Email the photos to yourself with the subject line "Move-In Photos — [Address] — [Date]." This creates a timestamped record that's admissible in a tenancy dispute.

The inspection report: Fill out the move-in inspection report within your province's deadline (usually 7-14 days). Take photos of the completed report. Submit it in writing.

Checklist

- ☐ Apartment photographed (every wall, floor, surface)
- ☐ All taps and toilets tested
- ☐ All lights and outlets tested
- ☐ Parking spot confirmed
- ☐ Plunger, toilet paper, sheets, towel purchased
- ☐ Cleaning supplies purchased
- ☐ Box cutter or scissors ready
- ☐ Lease scanned and stored on phone
- ☐ Move-in inspection report filled out
- ☐ Landlord emergency contact saved
- ☐ Tenant insurance policy number saved

Key Takeaway

The first hour sets the tone for the entire move. Photograph everything, test everything, and buy the essentials before the truck arrives. Fifteen minutes of preparation saves hours of frustration.

02

CHAPTER 2 OF 12

Unpack by Zone

*“You're standing in the middle of the living room, surrounded
by cardboard, not sure where to start.”*

Chapter Hook

The boxes are in. Every room has a stack. You're standing in the middle of the living room, surrounded by cardboard, not sure where to start. Most people start with the kitchen because it seems logical. That's a mistake.

Why This Matters

Most people unpack by box, opening whatever is on top. This leaves the kitchen functional but your bedroom inaccessible for days. You end up sleeping on the couch, eating takeout, and feeling like you're camping in your own apartment.

The smarter approach is unpacking by zone — starting with the room that matters most for your immediate well-being.

The Build

Zone 1 — Bedroom (unpack first). Even if nothing else gets done, you need a place to sleep. Set up the bed frame and mattress, unpack sheets and pillows, hang one lamp. This should be the first thing you do after the boxes are in.

Zone 2 — Bathroom. Unpack towels, toiletries, and the shower curtain. Use a temporary caddy rather than organizing the vanity perfectly. You can organize later — for now, you just need to be able to shower.

Zone 3 — Kitchen. Unpack only what you need for the first week: one set of dishes, two pots, basic utensils, coffee maker. Everything else stays in boxes until you've lived in the space long enough to know where you want it.

Zone 4 — Everything else. With the essentials settled, deal with boxes at your own pace over the next month.

The one-week rule: If you haven't unpacked a box after one week, you probably don't need what's in it. Stack those boxes in a corner. Most people find they can donate or store 30-40% of what they brought without ever missing it.

Design Insight

Interior designers use a principle called "**layering**" — you don't furnish a room all at once. You start with the essentials (bed, sofa, table) and add layers over time (art, accessories, decor). The same principle applies to unpacking. Start with the essentials. Add layers as you settle in.

Real Example

Sarah, Vancouver studio, 400 sq ft

Sarah unpacked by box on move-in day. She opened the kitchen boxes first because they were on top. By evening, her kitchen was organized but she had no bed set up. She slept on the floor.

Before: Sarah spent her first night on the floor.

Actions taken: On her next move, she unpacked by zone. Bedroom first, bathroom second, kitchen third. She was asleep in her own bed by 9 PM on move-in day.

Lessons learned: The zone order matters. Bedroom first, always. Everything else can wait.

Quick Wins

- **Set up your bed first.** Before anything else.
- **Unpack one box** from each zone, not all boxes from one zone.
- **Stack untouched boxes** in a corner after one week.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Unpacking by box order. The box on top is rarely the box you need. Unpack by zone.

Mistake #2: Trying to organize everything perfectly on day one. You don't know your new space yet. Live in it for a month before making permanent decisions.

Designer Tips

The first-night box: Pack one box with everything you need for the first 24 hours: sheets, pillow, towel, toiletries, phone charger, change of clothes, coffee mug. Label it "OPEN FIRST." This box saves you from digging through 20 boxes at 11 PM.

The temporary home: Use a cardboard box as a temporary drawer. It's not beautiful, but it works until you find the right furniture.

The one-month rule: Don't buy any furniture or storage for the first month. Live in the space. Learn how you use it. Then buy what you actually need.

Checklist

- ☐ Bed set up first (frame, mattress, sheets, pillow)
- ☐ Bathroom unpacked (towel, toiletries, shower curtain)
- ☐ Kitchen unpacked (first-week essentials only)
- ☐ One-week rule applied to remaining boxes

- ☐ First-night box packed and accessible

Key Takeaway

Unpack by zone, not by box. Bedroom first, bathroom second, kitchen third. Everything else can wait. You need to sleep, shower, and eat. Everything else is a bonus.

03

CHAPTER 3 OF 12

Address Registration

“The last thing you want to do is paperwork.”

Chapter Hook

You've moved in. The boxes are everywhere. You're exhausted. The last thing you want to do is paperwork. But the paperwork has deadlines — and missing them costs money.

Why This Matters

Missing an address change can mean missed bills, cancelled insurance, delayed mail for months, and fines for late registration. Each province has different deadlines for driver's licence and vehicle registration updates. Missing them can result in fines.

The Build

Day 2 is address day. Do all of these on your second day in the apartment:

1. **Canada Post** — redirect your mail (\$50 for 3 months, \$75 for 6 months). This catches anything you miss. Do this online in 10 minutes.
2. **Provincial health card** — update online or in person. Each province has a different process. Ontario: ServiceOntario. BC: ICBC. Alberta: Alberta Health.
3. **Driver's licence and vehicle registration** — each province has a deadline (usually 30-90 days). Check your province's requirement. Fines for late registration vary.

4. **CRA** — update online through My Account. Critical for tax season and benefit payments like the Canada Child Benefit, GST/HST credit, and Climate Action Incentive.
5. **Insurance** — update your tenant insurance with your new address. Also update car insurance — your rate may change based on your new neighbourhood.
6. **Bank, credit cards, subscriptions** — update your billing address. Start with the accounts that send physical bills.

Create a note on your phone called "Address Update List" with all accounts that need your address. Check off each one as you update it. This list will save you hours on your next move too.

Design Insight

The best system for address changes is what designers call "**a single source of truth**" — one list that contains everything. Instead of remembering which accounts need updating, you have one list that tells you. Create it once, use it for every move.

Real Example

James, Montreal one-bedroom, 500 sq ft

James forgot to update his address with CRA. He missed a GST credit cheque that was sent to his old address. By the time he realized, the cheque had been cashed by someone else.

Before: James lost a government payment because his address was wrong.

Actions taken: He created a note on his phone called "Address Update List" with 15 accounts. On his next move, he checked off each one on day 2.

After: James has used the same list for three moves. He updates it every time he opens a new account.

Lessons learned: The list is the system. Without it, you'll forget something. With it, you won't.

Quick Wins

- **Create the list** right now. Open your phone and type "Address Update List."
- **Update Canada Post** first — it catches everything else.
- **Set a reminder** for your province's driver's licence deadline.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Assuming mail forwarding is enough. Canada Post forwarding lasts 3-6 months. After that, mail goes to your old address. Update each account individually.

Mistake #2: Forgetting CRA. CRA sends benefit payments by mail. If your address is wrong, you miss payments. Update CRA first.

Designer Tips

The recurring list: Keep the Address Update List in a note app (Apple Notes, Google Keep). Add new accounts as you open them. By your third move, the list is comprehensive.

The 30-day check: One month after moving, check if any mail is still going to your old address. If so, you missed an account.

The digital-first approach: Switch as many accounts as possible to paperless billing. Fewer physical bills = fewer things to update.

Checklist

- ☐ Canada Post mail forwarding set up
- ☐ Provincial health card updated
- ☐ Driver's licence updated (check deadline)
- ☐ Vehicle registration updated
- ☐ CRA updated online
- ☐ Tenant insurance updated
- ☐ Car insurance updated
- ☐ Bank and credit cards updated
- ☐ Subscriptions updated
- ☐ Address Update List created on phone

Key Takeaway

Day 2 is address day. One list, one day, done. Missing a single update can cost you money. The list takes 10 minutes to create and saves hours on every future move.

04

CHAPTER 4 OF 12

Utilities

“You assumed the landlord handled everything.”

Chapter Hook

You're standing in the dark. The internet doesn't work. The hydro isn't connected. You assumed the landlord handled everything. They didn't.

Why This Matters

In most Canadian apartments, you have two things to set up separately from the landlord: hydro/electricity and internet. If you don't set them up before move-in day, you'll arrive to a dark, disconnected apartment.

The Build

Hydro/electricity: Set up at least a few days before move-in. Each province has a different provider:

- Ontario: Hydro One, Toronto Hydro, or local utility
- British Columbia: BC Hydro
- Alberta: Enmax, Epcor, or Direct Energy
- Quebec: Hydro-Québec
- Nova Scotia: Nova Scotia Power

Internet: Schedule installation for Day 3 or 4, not Day 1. The first two days are too chaotic for a technician visit.

Timeline:

- 1 week before: Set up hydro

- 3-5 days before: Schedule internet
- Move-in day: Confirm hydro is active. Test all outlets and lights.
- Day 3-4: Internet installation

Check if your building has an exclusive deal with one internet provider (many new buildings do). If fibre optic is available, choose that over cable.

Design Insight

The best time to set up utilities is **before you need them**. Setting up hydro a week before move-in costs nothing and ensures you arrive to a lit apartment. Waiting until move-in day means you might spend your first night in the dark.

Real Example

Emma, Calgary one-bedroom, 500 sq ft

Emma assumed her landlord handled hydro. She arrived on move-in day to a dark apartment. The power wouldn't be connected for three days.

Before: Emma spent her first three nights in a cold, dark apartment.

Actions taken: She called the utility company and paid an expedited connection fee (\$50). The power was on the next day.

Lessons learned: Never assume the landlord handles utilities. Confirm what's included in your lease and set up everything else before move-in day.

Quick Wins

- **Call the utility company** one week before move-in. Takes 15 minutes.

- **Schedule internet** for Day 3 or 4.
- **Test all outlets** on move-in day.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Assuming utilities are included. Check your lease. If hydro isn't listed as included, you need to set it up.

Mistake #2: Scheduling internet on move-in day. The technician arrives, you're surrounded by boxes, and you can't focus. Schedule for Day 3 or 4.

Designer Tips

The fibre preference: If fibre optic internet is available, choose it over cable. Faster, more reliable, and often the same price.

The building deal: Many new buildings have an exclusive deal with one internet provider. Check with your building manager before shopping around.

The auto-pay setup: Set up automatic payments for hydro and internet on day one. One less thing to remember each month.

Checklist

- ☐ Hydro/electricity set up before move-in
- ☐ Internet scheduled for Day 3 or 4
- ☐ All outlets tested on move-in day
- ☐ Building's internet provider checked
- ☐ Auto-pay set up for both utilities

Key Takeaway

Set up hydro before move-in day. Schedule internet for Day 3 or 4.

Two calls, 30 minutes total, and you arrive to a lit, connected apartment.

05

CHAPTER 5 OF 12

Tenant Insurance

“Your lease says you need tenant insurance.”

Chapter Hook

Your lease says you need tenant insurance. You're not sure what it covers or how much it costs. You're tempted to skip it.

Why This Matters

Your lease almost certainly requires tenant insurance. If it doesn't, get it anyway. Tenant insurance in Canada costs \$15-25/month. Without it, a single incident — a fire, a flood, a break-in — can cost you everything you own.

The Build

What it covers:

- Personal belongings (\$30,000-50,000 typical)
- Liability if someone is injured in your unit
- Additional living expenses if your unit becomes uninhabitable

Choosing a policy:

- Replacement cost coverage (pays what it costs to replace new) rather than actual cash value (pays depreciated value)
- A deductible you can afford — \$500 is standard
- Positive reviews for claims processing

One-time inventory: Spend 30 minutes walking through your apartment with your phone camera, recording every item of value. Open drawers, closets, cabinets. Narrate what you're filming. Store the video in cloud storage. If you ever need to make a claim, this video is worth more than the receipt you lost three years ago.

Design Insight

Insurance is what designers call "**the invisible layer.**" You don't see it, you don't think about it, but it protects everything you've built. The 30 minutes it takes to film your inventory is the highest-ROI 30 minutes of your entire move.

Real Example

David, Toronto studio, 400 sq ft

David's building had a small fire in a neighbouring unit. His apartment wasn't damaged by fire, but the sprinklers caused water damage to his furniture and electronics.

Before: David didn't have tenant insurance.

Actions taken: He filed a claim with his building's insurance, but it only covered structural damage. His personal belongings — \$8,000 worth — were not covered.

After: David now has tenant insurance and has filmed his inventory. He tells every friend who moves to get insurance on day one.

Lessons learned: Tenant insurance costs \$15-25/month. Without it, a single incident can cost thousands.

Quick Wins

- **Get a quote** from three providers. Takes 15 minutes.

- **Film your inventory** right now. Takes 30 minutes.
- **Store the video** in cloud storage (Google Drive, iCloud, Dropbox).

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Choosing actual cash value over replacement cost. ACV pays you what your items are worth today (depreciated). Replacement cost pays what it costs to buy new. The difference is significant.

Mistake #2: Not filming your inventory. Without evidence, claims are harder to prove. A 30-minute video is the best evidence you can have.

Designer Tips

The bundle discount: Many insurers offer a discount if you bundle tenant and car insurance. Ask about it.

The annual payment: Paying annually instead of monthly often saves 5-10%.

The inventory app: Apps like Sortly or Encircle help you catalog your belongings with photos, receipts, and values.

Checklist

- ☐ Tenant insurance purchased
- ☐ Replacement cost coverage selected
- ☐ Deductible confirmed (\$500 standard)
- ☐ Inventory video filmed and stored in cloud
- ☐ Policy number saved on phone
- ☐ Claim line saved on phone

Key Takeaway

Tenant insurance costs \$15-25/month and protects everything you own. Film your inventory, choose replacement cost coverage, and set it up on day one. The 30 minutes it takes is the best investment of your move.

06

CHAPTER 6 OF 12

The Landlord Relationship

“The garbage chute, the laundry room, the parking, the recycling.”

Chapter Hook

You've moved in. You have questions. The garbage chute, the laundry room, the parking, the recycling. You need to talk to your landlord. But you've never met them.

Why This Matters

The relationship you build with your landlord in the first week determines how easy it is to get repairs, ask questions, and resolve issues for the rest of your tenancy. A good relationship makes everything easier. A bad one makes everything harder.

The Build

Introduce yourself in the first week. Send a brief email or text introducing yourself, confirming your contact information, and asking about building rules. This establishes a communication channel before anything goes wrong.

First week communication:

- Confirm your preferred communication method (email, text, phone)
- Ask about building rules (garbage, recycling, parking, guests, noise)
- Ask about maintenance procedures (how to submit a request, expected response time)

Maintenance requests: When something breaks, document it immediately with photos. Send it through your agreed-upon channel. If you don't hear back within 48 hours, follow up. In most Canadian provinces, landlords have a legal obligation to respond within a reasonable timeframe.

Design Insight

The best landlord relationships are built on **proactive communication**. A brief introduction before anything goes wrong establishes you as a responsible tenant. When something does go wrong, the landlord already knows you and is more likely to respond quickly.

Real Example

Maria, Vancouver one-bedroom, 500 sq ft

Maria's toilet started leaking on day three. She didn't have her landlord's contact information saved. She spent an hour searching for it.

Before: Maria had no relationship with her landlord.

Actions taken: She found the number, called, and the landlord sent a plumber the next day. But the interaction was tense because it was their first contact.

Lessons learned: Maria now introduces herself to every landlord on day one. She saves their contact information immediately. When something breaks, the relationship is already established.

Quick Wins

- **Send a text** to your landlord introducing yourself. Takes 2 minutes.
- **Save their contact** in your phone.

- **Ask about building rules** before you need to know them.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Not introducing yourself. The first contact with your landlord should not be a complaint. Establish the relationship first.

Mistake #2: Not documenting maintenance requests. Verbal requests are easily forgotten. Always follow up in writing (email or text).

Designer Tips

The written record: Always communicate about maintenance in writing. Email or text creates a record. Verbal conversations can be forgotten or disputed.

The 48-hour rule: If you haven't heard back in 48 hours, follow up. Most landlords are responsive, but things get missed.

The photo evidence: Photograph any issue before and after it's fixed. This protects both you and the landlord.

Checklist

- ☐ Landlord introduced yourself
- ☐ Contact information saved in phone
- ☐ Preferred communication method confirmed
- ☐ Building rules clarified
- ☐ Maintenance procedures understood

Key Takeaway

Introduce yourself to your landlord in the first week. A brief introduction before anything goes wrong establishes a positive relationship that makes everything easier for the rest of your tenancy.

07

CHAPTER 7 OF 12

The First Week Plan

“You have seven days to turn an empty box-filled apartment into a home.”

Chapter Hook

You have seven days to turn an empty box-filled apartment into a home. Here's exactly what to do each day.

Why This Matters

A structured first week prevents the chaos that leaves people feeling unsettled for months. Each day has a specific focus. By day seven, you're not done — but you're functional.

The Build

Day 1 — Essentials only. Set up the bed, unpack the bathroom, clear a path to the front door. Order takeout. Don't cook. Don't organize. Just survive.

Day 2 — Kitchen and living room. Set up first-week kitchen essentials. Unpack the couch and one surface. Create one comfortable place to sit.

Day 3 — Internet and workspace. While the technician is there, set up your desk essentials: laptop, monitor, keyboard, one lamp. Having your workspace functional reduces stress significantly.

Day 4 — Deep unpack. Get everything out of boxes and into the room it belongs in. Don't organize yet — just get it out of boxes.

Day 5-7 — Rest and explore. Walk around your neighbourhood. Find the nearest grocery store, pharmacy, and coffee shop. On Day 6-7, finish remaining boxes and add one personal touch — hang a piece of art, arrange a bookshelf, place a plant.

Design Insight

The first week plan follows a principle called "**progressive complexity**" — start with the simplest tasks (sleep, shower, eat) and gradually add complexity (workspace, organization, personalization). Each day builds on the previous one.

Real Example

Tom, Halifax one-bedroom, 500 sq ft

Tom tried to do everything on day one. He unpacked every box, organized every drawer, and hung every piece of art. By evening, he was exhausted and his apartment was still a mess.

Before: Tom spent his first week feeling overwhelmed.

Actions taken: On his next move, he followed the day-by-day plan.

Day 1: bed and bathroom only. Day 2: kitchen and couch. Day 3: internet and desk. By day 7, he was settled without the exhaustion.

Lessons learned: Spreading the work across the week is more effective than trying to do everything at once.

Quick Wins

- **Follow the day-by-day plan.** Don't skip ahead.
- **Order takeout on day 1.** Cooking adds stress.
- **Walk your neighbourhood on day 5.** Knowing your area reduces anxiety.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Trying to do everything on day one. You'll be exhausted and your apartment will still be a mess. Spread the work across the week.

Mistake #2: Not taking a rest day. Day 5 is intentionally light. Your brain needs time to process the new space.

Designer Tips

The first-night box: Pack one box with everything you need for the first 24 hours. Label it "OPEN FIRST." This box saves you from digging through 20 boxes at 11 PM.

The comfort item: On day one, place one item that makes you happy — a photo, a plant, a candle. It makes the space feel like yours immediately.

The neighbourhood map: On day 5, walk to find the closest grocery store, pharmacy, coffee shop, and takeout spot. Knowing these four locations makes the first month dramatically easier.

Checklist

- ☐ Day 1: Bed, bathroom, path to door
- ☐ Day 2: Kitchen essentials, couch, one surface
- ☐ Day 3: Internet installation, workspace setup
- ☐ Day 4: Everything out of boxes
- ☐ Day 5: Rest, explore neighbourhood
- ☐ Day 6-7: Finish boxes, add personal touch

Key Takeaway

Seven days, seven focuses. Day 1: survive. Day 2: eat. Day 3: work. Day 4: unpack. Day 5: rest. Day 6-7: personalize. Follow the plan and you'll be settled without the overwhelm.

08

CHAPTER 8 OF 12

First Grocery Shop

“But you haven't been grocery shopping yet.”

Chapter Hook

You're hungry. The kitchen is functional. But you haven't been grocery shopping yet. You don't know where the nearest store is. You don't know what you need.

Why This Matters

The first grocery shop in a new neighbourhood is more than just buying food. It's your first exploration of the area. It's your first test of the kitchen. And it's your first step toward feeling like you live here, not just stay here.

The Build

Don't do a full grocery shop on Day 1. You don't know your new kitchen yet. Buy one meal's worth and cook it as a test run.

First week pantry:

- Coffee or tea
- Milk or alternative
- Bread and sandwich fixings
- Pasta and jarred sauce
- Eggs
- Fresh fruit
- One frozen meal for the night you have zero energy

Neighbourhood food map: Walk to find the closest grocery store, pharmacy, coffee shop, and takeout spot. Knowing these four locations makes the first month dramatically easier.

Design Insight

The first grocery shop is what designers call "**a discovery walk**" — a low-stakes exploration that builds familiarity with your new environment. The goal isn't just to buy food. It's to learn where things are, how long they take to get to, and what's available.

Real Example

Sarah, Toronto studio, 400 sq ft

Sarah's first grocery shop was a disaster. She bought two weeks' worth of food for a kitchen she didn't know yet. Half of it didn't fit in her tiny fridge.

Before: Sarah had a fridge full of food that didn't fit.

Actions taken: On her next move, she bought only one meal's worth of food. She cooked it as a test run. She learned that her fridge had one small drawer for vegetables and no freezer space.

After: Sarah now does a "test cook" before her first full grocery shop. She knows exactly what fits in her kitchen.

Lessons learned: You don't know your kitchen until you've cooked in it. Buy one meal first. Test. Then shop.

Quick Wins

- **Buy one meal's worth** of food for your first cook.
- **Walk to find** the closest grocery store, pharmacy, coffee shop.
- **Cook one meal** as a test run.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Buying too much food. You don't know your fridge, your pantry, or your cooking habits yet. Buy small.

Mistake #2: Not exploring the neighbourhood. The first week is the best time to explore. After that, you settle into routines and never discover what's nearby.

Designer Tips

The test cook: Choose one simple meal you know how to make. Cook it on day 2 or 3. This tells you everything about your new kitchen: where the pots are, how the stove works, whether you have enough counter space.

The neighbourhood map: On day 5, walk in each direction for 10 minutes. Note what you find. You'll discover coffee shops, parks, and shortcuts you'd otherwise miss.

The emergency meal: Keep one frozen meal in the freezer for the night you have zero energy. It's not about the meal — it's about having a backup plan.

Checklist

- ☐ First grocery shop: one meal's worth only
- ☐ Test cook completed
- ☐ Closest grocery store located
- ☐ Closest pharmacy located
- ☐ Closest coffee shop located
- ☐ Closest takeout spot located
- ☐ Emergency meal in freezer

Key Takeaway

Buy one meal, cook one meal, explore one neighbourhood. The first grocery shop is about learning your kitchen and your area, not about stocking a pantry.

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CHAPTER 9 OF 12

The First Month

“But the apartment doesn't feel like yours yet.”

Chapter Hook

The first week is done. You're functional. But the apartment doesn't feel like yours yet. The walls are bare. The boxes are still in the corner. You're not sure what to do next.

Why This Matters

The first month is when you transition from "I just moved in" to "I live here." The difference is intentionality. A space becomes yours when you make choices about it — what goes where, what stays, what goes.

The Build

Week 2: Hang your art and mirrors. A bare wall feels like you just moved. Even one piece of art changes the entire feel of a room.

Week 3: Organize your closet. By now you know what you wear frequently and what you don't. Donate or store what you haven't worn.

Week 4: Deal with remaining boxes. If you haven't needed something in a month, donate it. Most people find they can let go of 30-40% of what they brought.

The one-month review: Walk through your apartment and ask: what's working, what's not, what do I need to buy? Don't buy anything for the first month — live in the space first, then make decisions based on real habits.

Design Insight

The one-month rule is a principle used by professional organizers: **don't buy storage or furniture until you've lived in the space for one month.** Your assumptions about how you'll use a room are often wrong. Living in it first reveals the truth.

Real Example

Mike, Calgary one-bedroom, 550 sq ft

Mike bought a bookshelf on day three of his move. He placed it in the corner of his living room. By week three, he realized he never sat in that corner. The bookshelf was in the wrong place.

Before: Mike had a bookshelf in a spot he never used.

Actions taken: He moved the bookshelf to the other side of the room. It's now next to his reading chair, where he actually uses it.

Lessons learned: If he'd waited one month, he would have placed it correctly the first time.

Quick Wins

- **Hang one piece of art** in week 2.
- **Donate one box** of unpacked items in week 4.
- **Do the one-month review** before buying anything.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Buying furniture in the first week. You don't know your space yet. Wait one month.

Mistake #2: Keeping boxes "just in case." If you haven't needed it in a month, you don't need it.

Designer Tips

The one-month review questions:

- What do I use every day? (Keep accessible)
- What do I use once a week? (Store in a drawer)
- What do I never use? (Donate)
- What's annoying about this room? (Fix it)
- What's missing? (Buy it — after one month)

The donation box: Keep a box in your closet labeled "Donate." As you discover things you don't need, put them in the box. When it's full, drop it off.

The art rule: One piece of art per room is enough to make the space feel intentional. You don't need a gallery wall on day one.

Checklist

- ☐ Week 2: Art and mirrors hung
- ☐ Week 3: Closet organized
- ☐ Week 4: Remaining boxes dealt with
- ☐ One-month review completed
- ☐ Donation box started

Key Takeaway

The first month is about living in the space before making decisions. Hang art in week 2, organize in week 3, donate in week 4. Do the one-month review before buying anything.

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First Repair

“Something will break or need adjustment in your first month.”

Chapter Hook

Something will break or need adjustment in your first month. It always does. A leaky faucet, a running toilet, a stuck window. The question isn't whether something will break — it's whether you'll know how to handle it.

Why This Matters

Knowing which repairs you can do yourself and which require a landlord saves time, money, and frustration. Fixing a running toilet yourself takes 15 minutes and costs \$5. Calling a plumber costs \$150 and takes two days.

The Build

Fix yourself:

- Running toilet: replace the flapper (\$5 at Canadian Tire)
- Burned-out light bulb: replace it
- Sticky door: tighten hinge screws
- Slow drain: use a drain snake or baking soda and vinegar
- Loose cabinet handle: tighten with a screwdriver

Call the landlord:

- Water leaks (behind walls, under sinks)
- Electrical issues (sparks, flickering lights, dead outlets)
- Broken appliances (fridge, stove, dishwasher, washer/dryer)

- Pest problems (roaches, mice, bed bugs)
- Structural damage (cracks in walls, ceiling, foundation)

DIY toolkit every renter needs:

- Phillips and flathead screwdrivers
- Adjustable wrench
- Plunger
- Measuring tape
- Hammer
- Flashlight
- Drain snake

Design Insight

The best repair is the one you can do yourself. Most rental repairs are simple — a \$5 part and 15 minutes. The confidence that comes from fixing something yourself is worth more than the money you save.

Real Example

Emma, Toronto studio, 400 sq ft

Emma's toilet started running on day 5. She called her landlord, who sent a plumber. The plumber replaced a \$5 flapper and charged \$150.

Before: Emma paid \$150 for a \$5 repair.

Actions taken: She watched a YouTube video on toilet repair. On her next move, when the same thing happened, she fixed it herself in 15 minutes.

After: Emma now fixes running toilets, sticky doors, and slow drains herself. She estimates she's saved \$500 in unnecessary service calls.

Lessons learned: Most rental repairs are simple. A \$10 toolkit and 15 minutes on YouTube can save hundreds of dollars.

Quick Wins

- **Buy a basic toolkit** (\$20 at Canadian Tire).
- **Watch one YouTube video** on fixing a running toilet.
- **Test your DIY skills** on something simple (tighten a screw, replace a bulb).

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Calling the landlord for everything. Simple repairs are faster and cheaper to do yourself.

Mistake #2: Attempting repairs that require a professional. Water leaks, electrical issues, and structural damage are the landlord's responsibility.

Designer Tips

The YouTube rule: Before calling the landlord, search YouTube for "[problem] repair rental." Most common issues have a 5-minute tutorial.

The toolkit investment: A \$20 toolkit pays for itself on the first repair. Keep it in a drawer, not a closet.

The spare parts drawer: Keep a few common spare parts: toilet flapper (\$5), light bulbs, batteries, drain snake (\$8). When something breaks, you have the part ready.

Checklist

☐ Basic toolkit purchased

- ☐ Toilet flapper replacement watched on YouTube
- ☐ Landlord's repair request process known
- ☐ Spare parts drawer started
- ☐ DIY vs. landlord decision framework understood

Key Takeaway

Fix it yourself if it's simple. Call the landlord if it's serious. A \$20 toolkit and 15 minutes on YouTube save hundreds of dollars. Most rental repairs are simpler than you think.

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First Guest

“You’ve been in your apartment for two weeks.”

Chapter Hook

You've been in your apartment for two weeks. A friend wants to come over. You look around and see boxes, bare walls, and a general sense of "not ready."

Why This Matters

Inviting someone over is a milestone. It means your apartment is becoming a home. But the pressure to have everything perfect can keep you from hosting at all. The secret: guests don't care about perfection. They care about feeling welcome.

The Build

Invite guests after Week 2, not before. By Week 2 you have a functioning bedroom, kitchen, and living room. You don't need everything organized — you just need the essentials.

30-minute guest prep:

1. Clear the entryway (10 min)
2. Wipe the kitchen counter and table (10 min)
3. Flush the toilet and wipe the bathroom mirror (5 min)
4. Light a candle or open a window (5 min)

First dinner party: Keep it simple — takeout, wine, good company. Don't cook a complicated meal while you're still learning your kitchen.

Design Insight

The best hosts understand that **guests don't see what you see**. They don't notice the box in the corner or the unorganized closet. They notice whether they feel welcome. A candle, a clean bathroom, and a warm greeting matter more than a perfectly styled apartment.

Real Example

James, Vancouver one-bedroom, 500 sq ft

James wanted to invite friends over but kept postponing because his apartment "wasn't ready." Three months later, he still hadn't hosted anyone.

Before: James was isolating himself because of perfectionism.

Actions taken: He invited one friend over for coffee. He spent 30 minutes prepping. The friend didn't notice the boxes or the bare walls.

After: James now hosts regularly. He's learned that guests care about connection, not perfection.

Lessons learned: The barrier to hosting was internal, not external. Guests don't see what you see.

Quick Wins

- **Invite one person** over this week.
- **Spend 30 minutes** prepping.
- **Order takeout** — don't cook.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Waiting until everything is perfect. It never will be. Host now.

Mistake #2: Cooking a complicated meal. You don't know your kitchen yet. Keep it simple.

Designer Tips

The 30-minute rule: Any apartment can be guest-ready in 30 minutes. Entryway, kitchen counter, bathroom mirror, candle. That's it.

The takeout strategy: Your first dinner party should be takeout. It removes cooking stress and lets you focus on your guests.

The one-room focus: If the whole apartment isn't ready, make one room comfortable. Guests will naturally gather there.

Checklist

- ☐ Guest invited after Week 2
- ☐ 30-minute prep completed
- ☐ Entryway cleared
- ☐ Kitchen counter wiped
- ☐ Bathroom mirror wiped
- ☐ Candle lit or window opened
- ☐ Takeout ordered (not cooking)

Key Takeaway

Guests don't see what you see. They care about feeling welcome, not about perfect organization. Invite someone over after Week 2. Spend 30 minutes prepping. Order takeout. Enjoy the company.

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CHAPTER 12 OF 12

You're Settled

“You've been in your apartment for a month.”

Chapter Hook

You've been in your apartment for a month. The boxes are gone. The walls have art. You know where the nearest coffee shop is. You've fixed a running toilet. You've hosted a friend. You're settled.

Why This Matters

Being settled isn't about having everything perfect. It's about feeling like you belong. It's about knowing where things are, how things work, and that you can handle what comes up.

The Build

You're officially settled when:

- You can find any item within 30 seconds
- You've cooked at least three meals in your kitchen
- You know your neighbours by sight
- You have a favourite coffee spot
- Your apartment feels like yours

Celebrate the milestone. Moving is one of the most stressful life events. When you've completed your first month, acknowledge that you did something hard.

Next move prep: Start a folder on your phone called "Next Move." Save photos of your furniture layout, note which items you wish you hadn't brought, and keep a list of ⁶³companies you'd use again.

Design Insight

The transition from "I just moved in" to "I live here" happens when you stop thinking about your apartment as a temporary space and start treating it as your home. That shift is psychological, not physical. It happens when you make choices — what to hang, what to keep, what to change.

Real Example

Sarah, Toronto studio, 400 sq ft

Sarah felt unsettled for three months after moving. She kept her boxes in the corner "just in case." She didn't hang art because she wasn't sure she'd stay.

Before: Sarah was living in a temporary space.

Actions taken: She unpacked the last box, hung her favourite print, and bought a plant. She stopped saying "I just moved in" and started saying "I live here."

After: Sarah's apartment feels like home. She's been there for two years.

Lessons learned: The shift from temporary to permanent is a choice. You don't have to wait until you own the place to treat it like home.

Quick Wins

- **Unpack the last box.** Even if you're not sure where things go.
- **Hang one piece of art.** It makes the space yours.
- **Say "I live here"** instead of "I just moved in."

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: Keeping boxes "just in case." Unpack them or donate them. Boxes in the corner keep you feeling temporary.

Mistake #2: Not celebrating. Moving is hard. Acknowledge that you did it.

Designer Tips

The home ritual: Light a candle, make tea, sit in your space for 10 minutes without screens. This ritual signals to your brain that this is home.

The next move folder: Start it now, not when you're moving. Save photos of your layout, notes about what worked, and a list of companies you'd use again.

The gratitude practice: Every day for the first month, notice one thing you like about your apartment. It trains your brain to see the positive.

Checklist

- ☐ All boxes unpacked or donated
- ☐ Art hung on walls
- ☐ Neighbourhood explored
- ☐ Favourite coffee spot found
- ☐ First guest hosted
- ☐ First repair completed
- ☐ Next move folder started
- ☐ Milestone celebrated

Key Takeaway

You're settled when you stop saying "I just moved in" and start saying "I live here." Unpack the last box, hang the art, and celebrate the milestone. Your apartment is your home.

Conclusion

You did it. You moved. You unpacked. You registered your address. You set up utilities. You bought insurance. You fixed a toilet. You hosted a friend. You made it through the hardest week of renting.

Moving is one of the most stressful life events. But it's also one of the most rewarding. A new apartment is a fresh start — a chance to organize your space the way you want, to build new routines, and to create a home that reflects who you are.

What you've accomplished:

- A fully functional apartment by day 7
- All address changes completed
- Utilities and insurance set up
- A positive relationship with your landlord
- The confidence that you can handle what comes up

What's next: This guide is part of the SmallSpaceHome library. If you found the unpacking chapter useful, you'll love *The 1-Hour Apartment Reset* — a method for keeping your space calm and organized. And if the first repair chapter resonated, *The No-Damage Renter's Toolkit* will teach you everything you need to hang, mount, and organize without losing your deposit.

Visit smallspacehome.ca for more guides, a free weekly newsletter with organizing tips, and our complete library of small-space living resources.

Welcome home.

About SmallSpace Home

SmallSpaceHome.ca is Canada's trusted resource for apartment and small-home living. We help renters and small-space dwellers across the country make the most of every square foot — without sacrificing style, comfort, or their security deposit.

Our guides are researched, tested, and written by people who live in small spaces themselves. We believe that great design isn't about how much space you have — it's about how intentionally you use it.

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